

Lettrism, Astrology and Jazz Philosophy

in Ibn ‘Arabī’s *Allusions of the Quran in the World of Man*

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Incandescently freewheeling yet superhumanly disciplined, Ibn ‘Arabī’s works have long been and continue to be magical in their initiatory effect, as forty generations of commentators attest. But the Supreme Master saw the entirety of his own oeuvre as but a commentary on the Quran, in its infinite linguistic–mathematical iterations the very blueprint of the cosmos. A case in point is his minor yet equally visionary commentary *Allusions of the Quran in the World of Man* (*Ishārāt al-Qur’ān fī ‘ālam al-insān*) – an epitome of jazz philosophy.¹

1. RG 303. On a contemporary, even more freewheeling and equally influential version of the same boundless lettrist play, see Cyril V. Uy II, ‘Lost in a Sea of Letters: Sa’d al-Dīn Ḥamūya (d. 1252) and the Plurality of Sufi Knowledge,’ PhD diss. (Brown University, 2021). My thanks to Prof. Uy for this brilliant jazz-bebop metaphor. As he explicates:

Ḥamūya’s work makes meaning by twisting, warping, and exaggerating Sufi conventions to the point that they are almost unrecognizable. Nevertheless, like Dadaists, French post-structuralists, and free jazz pioneers, it is precisely *through* these ubiquitous forms – from *within* this shared field of play – that the shaykh’s strategies produce their most compelling effects ... We could say that the shaykh plays free jazz to the bebop of his contemporaries, using strategic bursts of shared vocabulary to evoke established conventions while simultaneously deconstructing the forms expected to accompany them. Like Coltrane’s *Meditations* (1966), each skittering phrase or abrasive texture from Ḥamūya’s *Levels of Joy* becomes meaningful not only through the cacophonous blur in which it is immediately situated, but also through the familiar frameworks it twists, warps, exaggerates, or negates through implication. That is to say, the full import of Ḥamūya’s avant-garde meditations on these forty Hadith is almost impossible to grasp without an advanced understanding of the material with which he is in dialogue. To continue with our *Meditations* analogy, the meaning that emerges from such a juxtaposition is not reducible to a set of propositions that can be decoded and mapped to more conventional forms ... [Reading him] is not

As a jazz philosopher, Ibn ‘Arabī, floodgate of revelation, refuses all systematization in his devotion to boundless play. Yet his play inspired a rigorous and systematic *philosophy of jazz* that would come to permeate Islamicate and especially Persianate cosmology, and, by extension, the practice of natural and mathematical science.² The gorgeous rhymed prose of *Allusions* accordingly riffs on, plays with and encodes as riddle the two occult sciences (‘ulūm gharība) that would become the specifically imperial core of the Akbarian legacy throughout the vast early modern Persianate world from the Timurid era onward: lettrism (‘ilm al-ḥurūf) and astrology (‘ilm al-nujūm).³

Although these sciences hardly dominate *Allusions*, their mention is always pregnant – sometimes literally! – and lettrism in particular runs like a red thread through the Master’s oeuvre. Indeed, it functions as a key to the *Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya* itself.⁴ We are now in the realm of *jazz science*.

Central to lettrist philosophy and its talismanic practice is the concept of the *majma‘ al-aḍḍād* or *coincidentia oppositorum*: Ibn ‘Arabī’s commentaries on the Sura of the Opening and the Sura of Thunder are among the most bewitchingly beautiful of his paeans to this governing principle. In this occult, Pythagorean context, that in the latter he explicitly invokes the tenth-century Brethren of Purity (Ikhwān al-Ṣafā’) is highly significant – for it is their fifteenth-century New Brethren of Purity namesakes who made Ibn ‘Arabī synonymous with lettrism as the new master science for universal Islamic empire.⁵

simply a question of unlocking a normative matrix of theory and practice within which his claims would suddenly click into place. (Uy, 28–9, 113–14)

2. Matthew Melvin-Koushki, ‘Powers of One: The Mathematicalization of the Occult Sciences in the High Persianate Tradition,’ *Intellectual History of the Islamicate World* 5, no. 1 (2017), 127–99.

3. Matthew Melvin-Koushki, ‘Early Modern Islamicate Empire: New Forms of Religiopolitical Legitimacy,’ in *The Wiley-Blackwell History of Islam*, ed. Armando Salvatore et al. (Hoboken, NJ, 2018), 353–75.

4. See, for example, Denis Gril, ‘The Science of Letters,’ in Ibn al-‘Arabī, *The Meccan Revelations*, ed. Michel Chodkiewicz, trans. Cyrille Chodkiewicz and Denis Gril, 2 vols. (New York, 2004), 2:105–219; and Dunja Rašić, *The Written World of God: The Cosmic Script and the Art of Ibn ‘Arabī* (Oxford, 2021).

5. Matthew Melvin-Koushki, ‘The New Brethren of Purity: Ibn Turka and the Renaissance of Pythagoreanism in the Early Modern Persian Cosmopolis,’

By the same token, the Master goes so shockingly far as to declare the obscure sura-initial disconnected letters (*muqattaʿāt*) demonstrative proofs (*barāhīn*)! The *majmaʿ* is very much an alchemical marriage too: it is the *ALM* that induces the author's coition with the heart-stoppingly beautiful, forward and jealous maiden that is his own soul to birth the Seal of the Age, the Master himself, transcendent of all opposites.⁶

Likewise, in *Allusions*, the divine Names are the very matrix of Creation, and the adept is urged to become the avatar of each in standard Sufi fashion (*takhalluq bi-akhlāq Allāh*). But Ibn ʿArabī, true to form, goes farther to astrologically paint prophets as avatars of planets – which he terms divinities (*lawāhīt*) – too: the irresistible Joseph is Venus, aspecting problematically and productively with Pharaoh and his Egyptian courtiers as Sun, Jupiter and Mercury. He also proposes what would seem to be a novel astrological timeframe for the Apocalypse: the conjunction of all planets in Cancer with the Moon in his domicile.⁷

Science aside, the Master brings his usual prescient audacity to Empire too. He had finally taken up his saintly duty to dispense

Intellectual History of the Islamicate World (forthcoming). They did the same for his Ifriqiyan contemporary Aḥmad al-Būnī (d.c. 1225–32) as pre-eminent lettrist mage to Ibn ʿArabī's lettrist sage; see Noah Gardiner, 'Esotericism in a Manuscript Culture: Aḥmad al-Būnī and His Readers through the Mamlūk Period,' PhD diss. (University of Michigan, 2014).

6. Cf. his romance with the Greek-Persian-Meccan Nizām as avatar of Islamic Empire.

7. For an account – equally allusive – of astrology in Ibn ʿArabī's oeuvre, see Titus Burckhardt, *Mystical Astrology According to Ibn ʿArabī*, trans. Bulent Rauf (Lexington, KY, 2001). In this occult context, it is highly significant that becoming planetary avatars for astral-magical purposes is a central theme of his famed correspondent Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī's (d. 1210) seminal grimoire *al-Sirr al-maktūm*; see Michael-Sebastian Noble, *Philosophising the Occult: Avicennan Psychology and 'The Hidden Secret' of Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī* (Berlin, 2021); on their seminal correspondence, see Mohammed Rustom, 'Ibn ʿArabī's Letter to Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī: A Study and Translation,' *Journal of Sufi Studies* 25, no. 2 (2014), 113–37. On a more systematic synthesis of these two occult sciences by two of Ibn ʿArabī's immediate heirs, Sunni and Shiʿi respectively, see Mohammad Amin Mansouri, 'ʿAziz-i Nasafi (fl. 7th/13th c.), Hierarchies and Islamic Cosmopolitanism,' PhD diss. (University of Toronto, 2022); and Mohammad Amin Mansouri, 'Walāya between Lettrism and Astrology: The Occult Mysticism of Sayyid Ḥaydar Ḥamuli (d.c. 787/1385),' *Journal of Sufi Studies* 9, no. 2 (2020), 161–201.

advice to kings, particularly the Seljuks of hinterland Anatolia, by the time of his composition of this work in 601/1205.⁸ His commentary here on the Sura of the Stoneland accordingly insists on the necessity of *philosopher-kingship* – as authorized by the immediately preceding lettrist meditation on ALR. This marriage of occult science to political theory was precisely the project of the New Brethren, who did succeed to an unprecedented degree in fashioning their Timurid, Mughal, Safavid and Ottoman warlord patrons into occult philosopher-kings – and even supreme axial (*quṭb al-aqṭāb*) saints in their own right. Ibn ‘Arabī’s theory of the cosmic hierarchy of sainthood was so enthusiastically adopted as imperial playbook throughout the Persianate world as to become a primary site of political legitimacy and rivalry down to the colonial period.⁹

As conquerors of Mamluk Damascus, however, the Ottomans sought to make Ibn ‘Arabī their proprietary patron saint by building his shrine and exalting his status as Muḥammadan Sainthood’s Seal by inscribing thereon his (in)famous declaration of the same:

Every age has one person through whom it soars –
for the rest of this age, I am that one!¹⁰

Testifying to this transformation, he makes a similar declaration here in equally compelling style in his commentary on the Sura of the Cow: he *is* the Age itself and perpetually so! Few poetical gauntlets have been thrown down to greater socio-political effect.

Allusions, though a relatively minor work, thus represents the Akbarian legacy fractally. It was written as a complement to the Master’s more popular *Revelatory Descents in Mosul on the Secrets of Modes of Purity and Prayer and the Primal Days (al-Tanazzulāt al-Mawṣiliyya fī asrār al-ṭahārāt wa-l-ṣalawāt wa-l-ayyām al-aṣliyya)*,

8. See, for example, Sara Nur Yıldız and Haşim Şahin, ‘In the Proximity of Sultans: Majd al-Dīn Ishāq, Ibn ‘Arabī and the Seljuk Court,’ in *The Seljuks of Anatolia: Court and Society in the Medieval Middle East*, ed. A. C. S. Peacock and Sara Nur Yıldız (London, 2013), 173–205; Stephen Hirtenstein, *The Unlimited Mercifier: The Spiritual Life and Thought of Ibn ‘Arabī* (Oxford, 1999), Ch. 13; and Jane Clark and Denis McAuley, ‘Manuscripts of Ibn ‘Arabī’s Works: Some Notes on the Manuscript Veliyyudin 51,’ *JMIAS* 40 (2006), 105–15.

9. For references, see Melvin-Koushki, ‘Islamicate Empire.’

10. Trans. in William Chittick, *The Sufi Path of Knowledge: Ibn al-‘Arabī’s Metaphysics of Imagination* (Albany, 1989), 322 (hereafter SPK).

dedicated to Badr al-Ḥabashī, which is, if anything, even more allusive. But the latter work contains little explicit lettrist or astrological content, even in the final section on the ritual and cosmic significance of the days of the week.¹¹ For that, we must turn, as always, to the oceanic *Futūḥāt* itself. Chapter 198, for example, among various other chapters, is rigorously astro-lettrist in its fusion of letters and divine and prophetic names with the lunar mansions and the planetary rulers of the seven days of the week. Thus, Wednesday's Mercury is there equated with the letter *T*, the name Numberer (*Muḥṣī*) and the prophet Jesus, who dwells in the sixteenth mansion, *Zubānā*; and Friday's Venus with the letter *R*, the name Former (*Muṣawwir*) and the prophet Joseph, who dwells in the fifteenth mansion, *Ghafr* – and Friday, the primordial Day of Congregation, is the best of days, as he proves at length.¹² This is the jazz-scientific context for Ibn 'Arabī's equation of Venus and Joseph in *Allusions*.



To give a taste (*dhawq*) of the Supreme Master's jazz science in this as yet little-studied work, I translate below, for the first time in any language, those eight sura commentaries in which it is most apparent: al-Fātiḥa, al-Baqara, Āl 'Imrān, Yūnus, Hūd, Yūsuf, al-Ra'd and al-Ḥijr. Since his treatment of later suras is much more abbreviated, this selection constitutes slightly over a full third of the whole

11. RG 762, aka *The Descent of Angels through the Motions of the Spheres* (*Tanazzul al-amlāk fī ḥarakāt al-aflāk*) and other variations, ed. Nawāf al-Jarrāḥ (Beirut, 1424/2003). The Master's mention of the planets here is limited to two short, decidedly unscientific passages in two chapters respectively: 3 (36) and 52 (146–7). The latter is directly preceded by a meditation on the divine name the Beautiful (*Jamīl*), and involves a quick visionary conversation with each planet in turn, while the former presents a unique epistemological typology as riff:

Know that the sphere (*falak*) of sainthood is the most perfect and complete encompassing sphere of the intellect, the sphere of prophethood is the most perfect sphere of the soul, the sphere of messengerhood is the near and triangular sphere of prime matter. The sphere of ignorance (*jahl*) is that of Saturn, the sphere of knowledge (*'ilm*) is that of Jupiter, the sphere of doubt (*shakk*) is that of Mars, the sphere of consideration (*naẓar*) is that of the Sun, the sphere of supposition (*ẓann*) is that of Venus, the sphere of imitation (*taqlīd*) is that of Mercury, the sphere of faith (*īmān*) is that of the Moon.

12. Ibn 'Arabī, *al-Futūḥāt al-Makkiyya*, 4 vols. (Beirut, n.d.), II:445.

work, and features many of its most remarkable episodes – more than enough to demonstrate his riffing procedure throughout.¹³ And since *Allusions* is entirely in *sajʿ*, I have not attempted to reproduce its cadence or rhyme schemes in English, which for obvious technical reasons would only obscure their import, but I do switch to free verse for certain passages of heightened visionary intensity. I have likewise kept notes to a minimum to increase readability, while adding Arabic technical terms in parentheses for the benefit of specialists, or to give an occasional sense of the literary logic of a passage. I take as basis the edition of Aimane Regragui in his unpublished 1998 Marmara University MA thesis, generously provided me by the Muhyiddin Ibn Arabi Society (MIAS); it has occasional minor transcription or vowelizing errors, but is otherwise clear and reliable.



Allusions of the Quran in the World of Man

Praise be to God, Who showers boons (*ʿawārif*), sends down subtleties (*latāʿif*), gives gnoses (*maʿārif*) and reveals the stayings (*mawāqif*) [of the Path] to the knowing (*ʿālim*), the wise (*ḥakīm*), the gnostic (*ʿārif*) and the stayer (*wāqif*) respectively! And blessing be upon Muḥammad, conquering trailblazer, remover of bars, render of bonds, revealer of realities (*ḥaqāʾiq*), conveyor of subtle connections (*raqāʾiq*),¹⁴ discriminator of details (*daqāʾiq*), veracious, loving, supreme, occulted yet resplendent morning star – God grant him blessing and peace, and likewise all his House, the master-caliphs of creation!¹⁵

To proceed: This book I have named *Allusions of the Quran in the World of Man*, [that is, such allusions] as I have clarified during

13. Specifically, 29 of 81 pages in Regragui's edition.

14. That is, 'the subtle lines of influence deriving from the divine names and tying all things together' (Chittick, *SPK*, 143).

15. Literally, *sādāt al-khalāyiq fī l-khalāyiq*, 'master-creatures among the creatures,' but with Regragui I take it to be rather *sādāt al-khalāyif*, 'master-caliphs' or 'sayyid-caliphs,' as this latter phrase is to be found elsewhere among the Master's works. Such pro-'Alid statements would help inspire the imamophilia of his equally staunchly Sunni heirs, the New Brethren in particular.

the course of various heavenly ascents (*ma'ārij*) and night journeys (*isrā'āt*) and through various of the thrones of the All-Merciful (*'urush raḥmāniyyāt*) and stationings thereupon (*istiwā'āt*). I have here elucidated [these allusions] sura by sura in such a way that the form [of this work] is perfected by the [nature of each] sura. The dignity [of any undertaking is defined by its] goal, which is inextricable from its beginning. It is I who discourse, but God who is importuned for the explanation!

Q.1: Sura of the Opening of the Book

He caught me away on a journey by night (*isrā'*) in the time of the present till that He lodged me in the present instant (*al-ān*). I was commanded to well consider – whereupon I beheld the Divine Names (*al-asmā' al-ilāhiyya*) in the past and the Engendered Names (*al-asmā' al-kawniyya*) in the future. So I sought this moment (*ḥāl*) [between them] and found myself therein, all the while beseeching His succor and guidance. I coited together by the means twain that are my opposite extremities my [physical] engendered existence (*kawn*) and my [transcendent] entity (*'ayn*) – *this very act* being my succor and salvation! And in darkness and light I saw the coitus of sorrow and bliss: for temporally I go aggrieved and blissful [at turns], but eternally I go blissful beyond all sorrow. Amen!

Q.2: Sura of the Cow

I was installed in the Ark of the Lordly Shekhinah (*tābūt al-sakīna al-rabbāniyya*) and the spiritous angels bore me.¹⁶ Within its darkness I opened my [inner] eye to ease my engendered existence of the miserable obscurity, and scrutinized the secrets of *ALM*,¹⁷ whereupon I declared: 'These are the very presence of the Pre-Eternal (*ḥaḍrat al-qadīm*)!' The Unseen dawned and all doubt evaporated. For belief (*īmān*) is proper to the soul (*nufūs*), unbelief (*kufṛ*) proper to the innermost heart (*asrār*). I saw it a sickness (*marad*) to nurse any ulterior motive (*gharaḍ*).

16. Q.2:248.

17. Q.2:1.

Then it appeared to me how divine guidance (*hidāya*) is sold to buy error (*ghawāya*):¹⁸

Thunder growls its tones / lightning flashes / [mankind] on trial!
 Heaven cast to earth / every place dark / every denizen at a loss
 striking a flame [to no avail] / all vision is blinded
 straining for a sound [to no avail] / all ears are deafened¹⁹
 trusting to the umbrage of *Be!* / to find it naught.
 Usurped they lay mute / moaning of suffocation.

Then it appeared to me how God gives in perfect semblance:²⁰ after my sight had remarked the fuel (*waqūd*) instilled at my core, I married the great to the lowly – and saw the shame (*istiḥyā'*) attributed to God for not leaving the cosmos as it is.²¹

Then it appeared to me how darkness is absorbed within light as deluginous waters within a boiling oven.²² I swore I would not interpret (*ta'awwul*), fearful lest I alter aught – and in the very act of swearing I was bequeathed vicegerency (*khilāfa*) over all mankind,²³ was supported by the hands and given the footstool for my feet; and when I had become ensconced in this position (*istiwā'*)²⁴ the divine Names rushed forth! The paradise sought [by all] drew near and my soul, my beloved, appeared and we were bound with the cords of union that constrain from all discord. So did this element of me come to save me from all speculation.

Then it appeared to me how a root is left though the branches be lopped; but when I requested a more detailed explanation of this matter I was told: 'Restrain yourself from witnessing (*mushāhada*) and cling to [divine] succor.' So did the supernal noses (*al-ma'ārif al-'ulwiyya*) descend accompanied by heavenly angelic beings (*ṭayyārāt*), so did rivers gush from out rock masses upon the trees [who drank nourishment from their roots].²⁵

18. Q.2:16.

19. Q.2:17–20.

20. Q.2:26.

21. Q.2:26.

22. Cf. Q.11:40, 23:27.

23. Q.2:30.

24. Q.2:29.

25. Q.2:60, 74.

Then we descended from sublimity to proximity: the revolving plant came to a standstill. I shed tears, realizing humility in the process.²⁶ He made me pledge (*mīthāq*)²⁷ not to seek special consideration.

Then the Isthmic Cow (*al-baqara al-barzakhiyya*) appeared to me. I was granted the [divine] attribute All-Regulator (*al-Qayyūm*).²⁸ My house prospered and its dead spoke, both the tearfully contrite and the fearfully apprehensive. I was commanded: ‘Don’t dare alter [a jot] (*taḥrīf*) after such an annunciation (*taʿrīf*)! I hereby remove from you all supposition – so keep to this waystation (*manzil*)!’

Then it appeared to me [that I must] issue a testament (*waṣīyya*) in honor of my forefathers.²⁹ Knowing myself to be the son of my stationing (*istiwāʾ*) [rather than son of any man’s flesh], and that my honoring it is precisely my installation upon it, I said to the angels [bearing] the Ark: ‘Bear me aloft to my father before I die! I have been commissioned executor of his property to fulfill his will.’ But then my father called me from out my Ark! Said I to myself: ‘I have no father. Live or die as you like.’

Then the secret of Noah appeared to me – I saw it consigned to the spirit (*rūḥ*). I inspected the source of merit in one’s being made to drink³⁰ and was astonished, and desired death; but lived. I was told: ‘The sign of one who fears not death is his desire for it!’³¹ So take the angels as your dearest friends and make them your shielders and protectors. Be wary of imaginal forms (*khayālāt*), which are but snares. If you lose anything in the engendered universe, see its substitute (*badal*) in its entity. Digress not to dispute with anyone not of your caliber – you will only find death. Build up your heart by remembrance [of God] (*dhikr*) and fend off its razing by rational reflection (*fikr*): true creation (*ibdāʿ*) is effected without thought and likewise all universes (*akwān*). When you’re tortured by words, beware the deception of signs (*simāt*). Take your seat on the throne of the most concentrated cosmos, to wit, the heart, to

26. Q.2:45–6.

27. Q.2:27.

28. Q.2:225.

29. Q.2:180.

30. Q.2:60, 93.

31. Q.2:94–5.

wit, Reality (*ḥaqq*). And prepare the pilgrim (*sālik*) for the rites [of pilgrimage].’

Then there appeared to me [true] religion (*ṣibgha*) and [its mere] manufactured imitation, I saw the Law (*shir‘a*) and [mere] innovation (*bid‘a*). I was told: ‘Contemplate (*i‘tibār*) – don’t cogitate (*iftikār*)!’

Then relative face-turning (*tawajjuh muqayyad*) appeared to me,³² and I saw the angel hunting. He said: ‘He bags his prey who knows its wiles. Whoever vanishes from His remembrance³³ has rendered His praise in full.’ He continued: ‘Whomever I befall will be balked of his desires. Look to the waymarks of purity laid down by the brethren of sincerity,³⁴ and beware lest you disavow [aught], which is gross-est removal [from the divine presence]. Cleave to the declaration of divine unity (*tawḥīd*) and the sheer mercy that is divine similarity [to creation] (*raḥmāniyyat al-ishtibāh*). Investigate [divine] free disposal (*taṣrīf*) and the mystery of conditionality (*tawqīf*).³⁵ Look to the sharing of love (*maḥabba*) and the categories of lovers.’

Then there appeared to me the cry of the drowned in the midst of the burning, forced to dissolution [in hell’s brimstony bath] – and thereby made to embody the Sending-Down (*akhlāq al-tanzīl*) [that is Revelation]: for so can a thing be substituted by another, like shade being changed for afternoon shadow.

Then there appeared to me concerning the seizing of refuge and the finding of sweetness,³⁶ and the emergence of crescent Moons from behind a vaporous curtain, and the scheduling of epiphanies (*mawāqīt*), and the mining of jewels (*yawāqīt*). I was told: ‘In illiberality is perdition and in liberality salvation!’

Then there appeared to me how the most perfect station is the end of any process, how essences (*dhawāt*) are expressed through

32. That is, ‘the manner in which [a divine name, for example,] exercises its properties and displays its effects’ (Chittick, *SPK*, 48).

33. That is, loses consciousness of self through practice of *dhikr*.

34. *A‘lām al-ṣafā’* ‘*inda akhillā’ al-wafā’*’, a play on the phrase *ikhwān al-ṣafā’* ‘*wa-khullān al-wafā’*’, the Brethren of Purity: see the Sura of Thunder below.

35. Chittick, *SPK*, 41: ‘Only those names can be attributed to God which have been attributed to Him by Himself in His revelations. This is the theological principle of “conditionality” ... which is based among other things on the courtesy (*adab*) that must be observed toward God.’

36. Chittick, *SPK*, 106.

accidents (*a'ṛād*) as disease (*adwā*) through illness (*amrād*). Whereupon He said to me: 'When I [alone] have become your journey's (*ṭariq*) provision, you will have reached your realization's (*taḥqīq*) destination, [though the journey is never-ending]. If however you take as provision My engendered cosmos (*kawn*), it will obtrude between you and My entity ('*ayn*). Remember Me after the pressing assembly at Muzdalifa with all due reverence, for that is the night of your union with Me and your transcendence of My creed (*madhhab*) – therefore sleep! For you are with Me beyond My limit (*ḥadd*) [of self-disclosure]. Yet beware My deception (*makr*) at the time of the sacrifice and your attendance at the table of the All-Merciful (*al-Raḥmān*), beware lest you say, May God have mercy on my father! [No] – you are with Me, so remember Me as your father, for I have chosen you [as My son].'

Then there appeared to me one fatuously pleased with himself on account of his gaudy finery, despite going to his own destruction. Security (*salām*) is in submission (*silām*) on all points of the [Law's] ruling.

Then cloud shadows appeared to me, which I declared to be emissaries of knowledge (*sufarā' al-ilmām*).³⁷ Then angels succeeded them, which I declared to be ruling spirits (*rūḥāniyyāt mālika*).

Then I returned to my witnessing (*shuhūdī*) and beheld the day of my finding [or: being] (*wujūdī*) – whereupon the realm of the ego (*nafs*) rose up against me! I invoked the holy spirit's (*rūḥ al-qudus*) battle-aid, and was accordingly advised: 'To conform not to individual desire is to cure disease. Beware of apostasy (*ridḍa*), for your

37. Q.2:57. Cf. Ibn 'Arabī, *Diwān* (Cairo, 1855), 41.15:

Clouds are the casting grounds of light –
even the lowest covers are sunwashed.
From them dawn every science despite all interdiction
and they unveil all sight.
Theirs are the lightning bolts whose brilliance robs not our sight
but rather hallows it,
Theirs are the thunderclaps whose blare deafens not our hearing
but rather thrills our hearts at their incomparability,
Theirs are the thunderbolts whose blaze incinerates not our traces
but rather preserves them,
Theirs is the fog whose flow destroys not our trees
but rather assures their love.

lifeterm ends suddenly. Beware the stumblings of drunkenness, the ultimate form of deception. By all means fraternize with [those of your own] type (*jins*) – companionship is a delight to the soul. But beware ever breaking off secret intercourse [with God] (*munājāt*) [simultaneously], except during witnessings (*mushāhadāt*).’

Then the being of the Tablet and the Pen appeared to me. I saw engendered things with the attributes of eternity (*qidam*), emanating from being (*wujūd*) and nonbeing (‘*adam*’) alike. So I quitted my soul and journeyed from the world of my senses (*ḥiss*) and overpassed the prescribed boundaries and the illusory (*wahmī*) waymarks, all earnestness in my desire for bounteous sufficiency (*jadd*). [Divine] munificence suckled me at the breasts of the gnostic sciences (*ma‘ārif*) for two years (in the years of a gnostic); and when my weaning was completed and my food upgraded, I fastened my skirt and donned my robe and arose in sedulous search of my subsistence (*baqā’*). I was hailed: ‘Only by maintaining balance [or: justice] (‘*adl*’) will you find subsistence. So forge ahead to encounter [the Beloved] through persistence in prayer and faithfulness in charity to the poor: for altruism is the best means of amassing good.’

Then the obligatory act as metaphor (*al-farḍ al-majāzī*) appeared to me, wherein I saw both my debasement and my exaltation. I was commanded: ‘Raze your natural constitution (*binya*)³⁸ and annul your term of life (*maniyya*) and I will rebuild you expansive in revelatory interactions (*mu‘āmalāt*) and descents (*tanazzulāt*). This Ark of yours in which you go is your bridge by which you cross over to Us. Scan in it the traces of the prophets, chosen and [ever-present] with Us. When the river that is the lower world (*dunyā*) overflows you, if you can manage to avoid drinking from it, your course will be infelicitably glorious; if you do drink – virtually unavoidable – take no more than a single ladling (*gharfā*): so shall you belong among the denizens of the seventh heaven (*ghurfā*) by the privation (*ḥurfā*) [you practice]. So know the number of this river’s stones and avoid performing the noon prayer’s ablutions here.’

Then ranking in excellence (*mufāḍala*) appeared to me, which I beheld in [the guise of] an archery match: each shot his arrow into

38. Given the rhyme, more properly *baniyya*, meaning building – perhaps here specifically the ‘building of Abraham,’ that is, the Ka’ba.

his own target and wore his rank on his sleeve – except the one who craved the increase of his knowledge.³⁹ He is the one whose followers and helpers and partisans we are, whose proper place is the Footstool (*kursī*), who possesses the [most] sublime station having *laid hold of the firmest handle*,⁴⁰ whose station is *God is better and more abiding*.⁴¹

Then there appeared to me the associate (*sharīk*) in the appointing of rulership (*tamlīk*),⁴² and I saw the disgracingly obvious argument as to the clear path.

Then as I surveyed the diffusion of the ages
and the transmutation of the stages
I tripped the slipping foot of error – and said
– This age shall not return! – and lulled upon my couch
and eras passed and casualties trod upon contingencies
and my inner eye opened and I beheld the ensuance of my bodily
being (*kawn*)
and became the auguries of the elements and said
– I am this Age (‘*aṣr*) and the [perpetual] contemporary
(*mu‘āṣir*)!
I create as I was created
and I demand reckoning as reckoning was demanded of me
and I answer as I was answered.
Gnosés teem exponentially
and subtleties proliferate with abandon
and I give freely of all I possess
and I strain – I terminate – my limit
and I am granted the wisdom of Weird (*mashī’a*) itself
and I am sold the world on credit!

Then the waysigns of [divine] guidance (*hidāya*) appeared to me, which I beheld [in relation] to their Existentiator (*Mūjid*). Their being profited me and I surrendered [my spirit] to their sheer munificence.

Then as the lodges (*zawāyā*) of engendered beings grew spacious and increasingly filled with the supplies of revelatory descents (*tanazzulāt*), I furnished myself with fire spirits (*rūḥāniyyāt nāriyyāt*) and approached the hereafter and turned over my nonbeing to my

39. This refers to the ubiquitous Prophetic hadith.

40. Q.2:256.

41. Q.20:73.

42. Q.25:2.

original state (*ḥāfira*) and staked it on my occult [form] (*ghayba*) and my manifest [one] (*shahāda*), on my dissent (*ibāya*) and my assent (*irāda*) – whereupon He returned me to myself and bestowed me upon myself. He said to me: ‘If you fulfill your capacity (*tāqa*) I will issue you your Doomsday pass (*biṭāqa*).’

*Our Lord, take us not to task if we forget, or make mistake. Our Lord, lay on us not a load such as You did lay on those before us. Our Lord, burden us not beyond what we have the strength to bear, and pardon us, and forgive us, and have mercy on us, for You are our Protector. And help us against the unbelievers!*⁴³

Q.3: Sura of the House of ‘Imrān

Says the alluder: Only the most astonishing answers could ever convince me in the case of arcana – and I had found *ALM* to be the epitome of both.⁴⁴ Thereupon overwhelming everlasting persistence (*qayyūmiyyat al-mazīd*) gifted me the steed of Onemaking (*tawḥīd*): so I clad myself in the garb of faith and secured a companion with whom to commence the journey. We set out by night on effaced footpaths and obliterated tracks and were guided by naught save the stars; we saw trace of no other wayfarer. When the pre-dawn gleamed, I said, ‘This must be our reward!’ My companion said, ‘Yes – nightfarers’ glory is daybreak.’⁴⁵ [Suddenly, it was as though] we had fallen in among shining troves of gold and all our weariness departed.

Then one of the spiritual dwellers of that place appeared to us, a willowy maiden (*jāriya*)⁴⁶ whose body swayed and whose buttocks glode – she caught away my heart! I throbbed with groans and torment. My companion chided me as the affect took hold on me – in

43. Q.2:286. The translation here and below is Arberry’s, with slight modifications (A.J. Arberry, *The Koran Interpreted*, New York, 1955).

44. Q.3:1.

45. This is a loose quotation of an Arabic proverb exhorting patience in difficulties, used, for example, in the forty-third *maqāma* of al-Ḥarīrī, whose subthemes of night travel and wife selection are reprised here.

46. More properly, concubine or female slave: a standard trope for a woman to whom a man can unreservedly express himself; see Gerald T. Elmore, *Islamic Sainthood in the Fullness of Time: Ibn al-‘Arabī’s Book of the Fabulous Gryphon* (Leiden, 1999), 300, n. 11.

fact, it startled him [in its force]. He said: 'I have that which is more beautiful than what you see here, so ask and I'll give you what you desire.'

But said the maiden: 'What are you thinking, blaming him on my account! We're the two of us kin.' So saying, she entered her oratory and declaimed: '*Prosperous is he who purifies her and failed has he who seduces her.*'⁴⁷

Then she exclaimed: 'My God! I proceed from Your munificence and this man here has fallen ecstatically in love [with me] through Your own agency! If his love pleases You, if his heart is unveiled, engorge his passion with passion! Don't wrench me from him! Haven't You Yourself created me for his sake and formed me in his image? Even were he to somehow disengage himself from me he would have to have someone else just like me, since I preside over his well-being as he presides over mine!'

I exclaimed: 'My God! I've surrendered [to Your will] (*islām*) and abandoned myself to Your decree, You who give dominion (*mulk*) to whom You will and seize dominion from whom You will,⁴⁸ You who are forever coiting spirit and soul and coupling intellect to the senses! With all this in Your power, who am I that Your munificence cannot find and encompass me!'

Said He: 'I've bestowed her upon you – so possess her completely! But be careful ejaculating your seed, for in you is the secret of lifegiving (*ihyā'*)! Trust yourself to the air, the secret of stationing (*istiwā'*) [on high]!'

So I made love to her – the full Moon necking the Pleiades! – and by morning had gotten her with a strapping child who was wrested from us and spirited away and given the name Seal of the Age (*dawr*), Terminus of the Cycle (*kawr*).

Thereupon my companion exclaimed: 'God be praised, who has orchestrated this union and joined this bond!⁴⁹ Now let her choose herself a saddled mount so she can accompany us on the right path!'⁵⁰ But she said, 'You go! I haven't the strength to travel. Traveling forces

47. Q.91:9–19. 'Her' refers to the feminine noun *nafs*, soul, psyche – that is, the maiden.

48. Q.3:26.

49. Q.3:103, 112.

50. Cf. Q.2:108.

you to socialize with others – and I’m so jealous (*ghayra*) I’m afraid of falling hopelessly into confusion (*hayra*).’

So I left her, hating to do so, but having no choice, whereas my companion left her exultingly – he was glad enough to abandon her. Impelled we went off questing after elevations (*marātib*) and traversing paths (*madhāhib*).

Whereupon there appeared to us the sign of *N* upon which was written, *You will not attain piety until you expend of what you love*.⁵¹ I said, ‘Which I’ve done!’ He said, ‘[No], you’ve clung. Hold fast to God’s bond, the bond of every clement and sensitive supplicant.’⁵² So I held fast and ascended and spied what I sought. Boons were lavished upon me. This I acknowledged and came to know what I had not known: I saw whiteness and blackness in the faces of lords and slaves.⁵³

Then an orator from among the highest spiritual beings (*rūḥāniyyāt ‘ulā*) ascended the highest pulpit and began to gush, lauding me unrestrainedly: ‘Yours is the most brilliant station and the nearest proximity and the most beautiful increase! You’ve forsaken the one you desire: so take from me what you crave. With it I will both establish your entity and felicitate your engendered being. So be generous in interactions and observe all courtesy upon mutual descents (*munāzalāt*). Spiritual entities (*rūḥāniyyāt*) will prosper you and the divine Presence buoy you.

‘Upon [divine] self-disclosure (*tajallī*), veil yourself from everything conducive to descent (*tadallī*). Don’t gaze at the engendered universe except [you discern] its Engenderer (*mukawwin*). Don’t excavate anything from its ore-bed, nor interact with it in controversion of the wisdom of its abode.

‘Don’t allow yourself to become veiled by my speech or regret my going, since the One who sent me descends Himself in every gleam (*lamḥa*) given you. When the lower world (*dunyā*) and the last world (*ākhirā*) expose themselves to you, saying ‘We’re your cousins, your close kin (*dinyā*)!’ – don’t deviate toward them however indispensable they are to you: give up precisely what is indispensable to you!

51. Q.3:92.

52. Such as Abraham: Q.9:114.

53. Q.3:105–7.

‘See Him whose beneficence you are and He yours, whose bounty you possess and He yours. Though you may well perish in His way,⁵⁴ never retreat: He will grant victory (*fath*) suddenly. Use tact when you question – but ply incessantly! Don’t entangle yourself in any joint (*mushtarak*) affair, for none who practices association (*shirk*) can prosper.

‘When He opens you to witness (*shahāda*), you will see something *weird*: life in death, attainment of the unattainable! Pay no attention to those who multiply [their possessions] – they’re the poorest of all: those who love what they possess are unlovable. So cling to Him as your possession and your total sufficiency.

‘Don’t conflate the realities of existents (*mawjūdāt*), since His foreknowledge of things entails their predestination (*majbūrāt*). But don’t let this knowledge delude you:⁵⁵ rather bring this ruling against Him – then guide yourself to Him and take up residence in your totality with Him.

‘If you are praised for a matter not of your concern, pay it no regard. Flourish your three abodes⁵⁶ with perpetual remembrance [of Him], be the sot and not the saki! Know that the choicest marrow of servanthood (*‘ibāda*) is supplication (*du‘ā*) – so make fast its cradle with pegs.’⁵⁷

Whereupon I was ordered: ‘Return to your young lady, the mother of your daughters! I’ve bestowed her upon you as a lush plaisance and a verdant garden.’ [So I returned:] she was overjoyed at my coming and excited by the largess of my reward!

*O believers, be patient, and vie you in patience; be steadfast; fear God – haply so you will prosper.*⁵⁸

54. Q.3:157–8, 169.

55. Q.3:196–7.

56. Body, soul, spirit.

57. Cf. Q.78:7.

58. Q.3:200.

Q.10: Sura of Jonah (peace be upon him) [rhyme in-ā']⁵⁹

Says the alluder: The cryptic (*mubham*) letters⁶⁰ are meant for inspired (*mulham*) souls, whereas vague souls are stupefied even at matters of common usage. The supports of the Lordly Foot (*al-qadam al-rabbāniyya*) are planted firmly. The Lord Creator is the final goal of benighted souls and intelligent minds alike. The matter concludes as it began, and the secret known is no secret, and the sway of divine decree (*qaḍā'*) acts on [one's bodily] members (*a'ḍā'*) as it deems fit.

Listen here, fool – how can you go on theologizing (*taklīm*) without saying (*takallum*) [anything of consequence]! How are you not awestruck at the pervasion of the light of the beginning in the end!

He who subjugates his heart (*fu'ād*) to rational thought (*fikr*) is denied the luscious delights of revelation (*wahy*), [stranded] at a station between the divine Address (*khiṭāb*) and mere unformed opinion, for whom meanings are a mixed potion of honey and gall. If only it knew the gravity of the situation – how it would strain to fly by night (*isrā'*) to heaven!

The worshiper (*'ābid*) is fortified by his pious merit, the aspirant (*murīd*) rewarded by his charismata (*karāma*), the gnostic (*'ārīf*) heard [on high] through his aspiration (*himma*), the divine sage (*ḥakīm ilāhī*) exalted by the precious stores he has hoarded: for the [Sufic] Tribe (*qawm*) beholds the All-Merciful as ensconced [upon His Throne] (*raḥmān al-istiṭwā'*).

Whoever is ignorant of the Benefactor (*Mun'im*) is reminded by way of boon (*ni'ma*), but whoever is ignorant of the boon has drowned in the sea of darkness. Yet he thereby settles in the stronghold of mercy (*mustaqarr al-raḥma*), the envy of the leaders of every nation, and is protected on all sides!

The scholar remains ignorant despite all his knowledge (*'ilm*), the ignoramus lies abject under the sway of illusion (*wahm*), the researcher is distracted by the details that drive his comprehension (*fahm*) – and the gnostic submits to the fact that [divine] affairs are carried out through such as these.⁶¹

59. Unlike previous chapters, in this chapter and the following Ibn 'Arabi imposes an overarching rhyme structure upon the internal *saj'* texture.

60. Such as the ALR of Q.10:1, 'the signs of the Wise Book.'

61. On Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī's contrasting valorization of *wahm* as the engine of

Whoever questions you⁶² about what you say is truly ignorant of it; thus virtue dictates that you answer his question. But once you see he is satisfied, sit no more with him, for you have nothing in common – rather sit with the All-Merciful on the Throne!

Those possessed of sage paternal souls and healthy filial bodies know that whatever they purpose to do is well known to the Knower of the Occult (*‘ālim al-khafīyya*), and so they refrain from doing evil.

Everyone who is forced to act as he acts (*mudṭarr*) is a monotheist however much a disbelieving polytheist, is just however unjust, is on track however lost, is pious however profligate: were it not so, God would never answer him when he calls out to Him for deliverance from his dire condition.

Whoever asserts the absolute Oneness of his Creator – and does so in the Muḥammadan mode – achieves eternal life. His witnessing (*mashhad*) rises to heights of sublimity unmatched by any other witnessing and he is graced with the gift of the night ascent (*isrā’*).

*And follow what is revealed to you and be patient until God shall judge – and He is the best of judges.*⁶³

Q.11: Sura of Hūd (peace be upon him) [rhyme in -ād]

Says the alluder: The letters that make fast the verses’ judgments are among the weightiest of demonstrative proofs (*barāhīn*).⁶⁴ Never take inability [as an excuse] when it comes to questing after the most perfect of goals. Don’t allow whatever level (*mustawā*) [you occupy] to veil you from [all other] stationings (*istiwā’āt*), and seek out what God has promised you – He will not fail the tryst.⁶⁵

Apprise whoever is ignorant of your current state and what you are about (*mā anta fīhi wa-‘alayhi*), teach whoever imposes their opinions on you to judge properly. If you neglect to counsel him, you wrong him, so retort gently: ‘Such evil you’re deluding yourself with! But know that your Lord is watching.’⁶⁶

talismanry, see Noble, *Philosophising the Occult*, passim.

62. Q.10:53.

63. Q.10:109.

64. In this case ALR (Q.11:1).

65. Q.3:9, 13:31, 39:20.

66. Q.89:14.

Whomever you call to your Lord that declines to answer – it is his loss. So don't fear his guile: your Lord is your helper, by means of His clarifying signs (*āyāt*) and His razor-sharp sword. Such a person will rue his behavior when calamities strike and he is thrown in with the [refractory] tribes of Noah and 'Ād.⁶⁷

When the [planetary] light forms (*hayākil al-anwār*) all conjunct in the sign of Cancer, with the Moon at the height of his power, and all hills and mountains lofty and valleys deep are leveled, save yourself [by sailing off] in the ship of your own essence (*dhāt*). But take care to avoid contending with Satan, and don't put in except at the shore of generous hosts!

Don't be deluded by things temporally bound, nor impressed by the pomegranate that [seasonally] produces sustenance, nor distracted by the timing of ritual observance from [perpetual] secret intercourse (*munājāt*) with your Lord. Is not the Mover of the celestial spheres – with their luminous [planets] and their [terrestrial] effects – capable of breaking the wont [of the cosmos at will] (*kharq al-mu'tād*)?⁶⁸

Address each sect (*tā'ifa*) using its own terminology (*iṣṭilāḥ*) and don't reveal to them any locked and recondite matter except in a form that admits of their key. But if their bird-spirits flutter about in their body-cages longing to be released from their prison and spoiling to rove, open space for them, with kindness and solicitude, among all the amplitudes of the celestial spheres.

[And if they do not:] shun all councils addicted to dispute, repositories of hatred and alienation, and haste away to the All-Merciful's station of union (*maqām al-jam' al-raḥmānī*). Be praiseworthy in all your comings and goings, though the comings of the recalcitrant be erased.

*To God belongs the Unseen in the heavens and the earth. To Him the whole matter shall be returned; so serve Him, and put your trust in Him. Your Lord is not heedless of the things you do.*⁶⁹

67. Q.9:70, etc.

68. Shades of the classic astrological doctrine: the stars incline but do not compel. Cf. Chittick, *SPK*, 99.

69. Q.11:123.

Q.12: Sura of Joseph (peace be upon him) [rhyme in -ā]

Says the alluder: When your goal is sublime, you will find none to help but be envied when you achieve it, and if [the results of your achievement] are made evident, it will only inspire the antagonism [of the envious] and the confusion of good ascetics and worshipers – so don't divulge [your triumph]!

The envious are content to fuse knowledge with inane supposition – O what ignorance! So do they deduce the full Moon of their true [natures] (*ḥaqīqa*) from its confinement within a halo, so do they remain confined therein – just as action constrains the actor – when they persist in ignorance of that commissioned to them as a trust (*wakāla*) at the beginning of creation (*inshā'*).

Three and ten has the property of one (*wāḥid*), though none but the Singular Man (*al-insān al-wāḥid*) will know my allusion here. Seen and unseen have become the same, the standing sit and the sitting stand, the traveler travels but doesn't go.

Banners are hoisted in honor of the faithful one (*amīn*)!⁷⁰ For his station encompasses the two types: those who call [upon God], stalwartly keeping vigil, and the cowardly and deficient, who nevertheless desire a return to fullness and completion, for they see the excellence of their original constitution.

Venus reveals her body's beauty! The Sun makes sublime her eminence, the spirit of Jupiter makes wondrous her course, the power of Mercury makes penetrating her insight and her sight untouched by any night-blindness.

But when these divinities (*lawāḥit*) beheld the beauty of her divinity (*lāhūt*), they rushed to cleave to her by rending [the garb of] her humanity (*nāsūt*), ignoring her imprisonment in the jail of her Ark (*tābūt*). Had they known that her glory comes by remaining resolutely in that Ark, they would have let it do with her as it pleases!

*It is not a tale forged, but a confirmation of what came before it, and a distinguishing of every thing, and a guidance and a mercy to a people who believe.*⁷¹

70. Q.12:54.

71. Q.12:111.

Q.13: Sura of Thunder [rhyme in -ayn]

Says the alluder: A is the prime regulator (*qayyūm*) of all the letters; L is the link of attribute (*ṣifa*) to attributed; M is knowledge (*‘ilm*) firmly attributed; R is the union of gnosis with gnostic and gnosed (*ittiḥād al-ma‘rifā bi-l-‘ārif wa-l-ma‘rūf*): for being (*wujūd*) has been bound up in binaries (*zawjayn*). When the blinding lightning blazes and the rolling thunder dins and the pregnant wombs birth and the flailing branches dance – then manifests the glory of the binary to whomever has eyes!

I was awestruck at One (*wāḥid*) from which are engendered all the multifarious things, I was amazed at the multiplicity within all the unified things, I was astonished at the opposition (*taḍādd*) between all the mutually similar things. But more astonishing than these are those who deny the resurrection of crumbled bones⁷² – this while engendering creation (*takwīn*) is constantly taking place before their very eyes through the coition of twains (*iltiḥām al-ithnayn*)!

Souls withdraw from their material bases (*jamādāt*) when they attach to their spiritual ones (*rūḥāniyyāt*) through acts of worship. Thereupon delightful things are distinguished from foul, and sublime glory established for the locus of all engenderings (*takwīnāt*); therein dwells true knowledge wherein is no lie.

When secrets descend from on high, every Chosen One (*muṣṭafā*) spies them; when lights pulse out by night, the Folk of Purity (*ahl al-ṣafā’*) inwardly receive them; when inrushes (*wāridāt*) come, they come to the Folk of Sincerity (*ahl al-wafā’*) only. Whoever has not these states remains teetering on the brink⁷³ with hands held fast in shackles.

Knowledge of the Book is only through [knowledge of] its Matrix (*umm*).⁷⁴ Those determined [to gain it] are ruled by their determination. But whoso knows it and loses time and stands alone in his finding it the governing principle [of all] (*ḥukm*) – his wings stay broken!⁷⁵

72. Q.17:49, 98.

73. Q.3:103.

74. Q.13:39; cf. Chittick, *SPK*, 240–1.

75. Ibn ‘Arabī uses the same descriptor for the pearl diver as sage shattered by gnosis in his *K. ‘Anqā’ mughrib*; see Elmore, *Islamic Sainthood*, 328–9.

Say: 'God suffices as a witness between me and you, and whosoever possesses knowledge of the Book.'⁷⁶

Q.15: Sura of the Stoneland [rhyme in -ān]

Says the alluder: Proper to A is primordial separation (*infiṣāl qablī*); proper to L is cardinal joining (*ittiṣāl qalbī*); proper to R is semblant commixture (*imtizāj mithlī*). Thus does the Secret of the Real (*sirr ḥaqīqī*) rise higher therein than with any of [their letter] sisters, however much the entities (*a'yān*) differ.

A single letter (*ḥarf*) marries insult to praise – a wonder most weird ('*ajab 'ujāb*)! But those with minds (*ahl al-albāb*) do not desire [in vain]. So say to those punished with the humiliation of veiling, speaking to them like a chamberlain from behind the curtain: 'So are idol-worshippers rewarded!'

Those who fall in love with imagining (*khayāl*) are barred from actually eyewitnessing ('*iyān*), [just as] those addicted to cavalier buying are ignorant of weights and measures. Those obsessed with division have not savored the delight of the unification that is the human being (*jam' iyyat al-insān*). But happy is he whose station is doing-the-beautiful (*iḥsān*), inviolate of the effects of engendered beings (*ta'thīrāt al-akwān*).

Clairvoyance (*firāsa*) is a type of inspiration (*ilhām*), leadership (*riyāsa*) is only through knowledge (*ilmām*), governance (*siyāsa*) hangs upon cases and judgments.⁷⁷ [The ruler] that realizes my maxims is singularly knowledgeable of what transpires by day and night.

*Proclaim your Lord's praise, and be of those that bow [in prayer], and serve your Lord, until the Certain comes to you.*⁷⁸

76. Q.13:43.

77. *Firāsa* more properly refers to physiognomy, a mainstay of statecraft by the early modern period; see Emin Lelić, 'Ottoman Physiognomy ('*ilm-i firāset*): A Window into the Soul of an Empire,' PhD diss. (University of Chicago, 2017).

78. Q.15:99.

ABSTRACT

Ibn ‘Arabi’s *Allusions of the Quran in the World of Man*, a minor and as yet little-studied work of 1205, epitomises his jazz philosophy more generally. Its rhymed prose also playfully riffs on and encodes as riddle the two occult sciences that would become the core of the Akbarian imperial–scientific legacy throughout the early modern Persianate world in particular: lettrism and astrology. To open this gorgeous, gnostic, visionary exegesis to comparative study, over a third is translated here, with emphasis on its astro-lettrist stylings.

KEYWORDS

jazz philosophy, tafsir, lettrism, astrology, imperial occultism, *coincidentia oppositorum*